

RESPONSE TO REVIEWERS

Dear Reviewers,

I would like to thank you for your very helpful comments. I have made the following revisions to this study to incorporate these suggestions.

Most importantly, I adjusted the methodology of the study to better exemplify the causal flow between media consumption and support for a political elite. The reviewers suggested that the underlying mechanism in that relationship is responsibility attribution, which had simply been included as a control in my original model. As the literature does indeed point toward media framings of responsibility being a key mechanism through which citizens justify or denounce political elites for violence actions, I separated my original model into a two-stage model. Doing so allowed me to conduct a mediation analysis with *responsibility attribution* as a mediator. This allows for more clarification of the nature of the relationship between the type of media one consumes and support for political elites.

I have also adjusted the introduction so that the analytical puzzle - why some Republicans distanced themselves from Trump and others did not, in the face of differing perceptions of the insurrection – is presented earlier.

Other edits include: the inclusion of plots depicting results of the new two-stage analysis, further theoretical elaboration of the mass media's role in constructing perceptions of political events, a more thorough discussion of this study's results and implications, and, lastly, the addition of coefficient and odds ratio tables, as well as descriptive statistics of the variables, in the Appendix.

Once again, I am greatly appreciative of the constructive feedback provided by the reviewers. I believe these revisions have greatly improved the quality of this study.

Sincerely,
Riya Anand

From Fox to Fracture: Republican Media Diets and Intraparty Realignment Post-January 6

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ABSTRACT

Affective polarization in the United States has intensified in the most recent decade, but not much is known about how moments of political violence shape intraparty affect, particularly within a party whose elites are associated with the event. News media environments may shape divergent perceptions of responsibility for the event, even within one political party. Using the January 6, 2021 attack on the U.S. Capitol as a case study, this article examines how the effect of media consumption on individuals' intentions to support a co-partisan elite associated with political violence is mediated by attributions of responsibility to this elite figure. Mediation analysis, using the Pew Center's American Trends Panel (ATP), shows that consumption of fringe right-wing media is associated with reduced attributions of responsibility to Donald Trump for the attack, while consumption of only mainstream conservative or neither type of right-wing media corresponds with greater blame attribution. Respondents attributing greater blame to Donald Trump were less likely to support him as a major national political figure for years to come. The study demonstrates how variation in media consumption contributes to differing perceptions of a political elite sully democratic processes, leading to the beginnings of intraparty realignment.

1. INTRODUCTION

Two months after his defeat in the 2020 presidential election, on January 6, 2021, thousands of then-president Donald Trump's supporters flocked to the U.S. Capitol building. Emboldened by Mr. Trump's repeated claims of election tampering, the rioters sought to prevent a joint session of Congress in which electoral votes from the 2020 presidential election were being certified. The insurrection turned violent and destructive through security breaches, conflicts with law enforcement and vandalism of the Capitol itself, a historic monument and symbol of democracy that had not been attacked in such a nature since the War of 1812 (Krakowski & Morales, 2025). Mr. Trump's role in stoking the flames of discontent post-election, including his hesitancy to denounce the rioters' destructive actions, made him culpable or at least partially responsible for the attack in the eyes of many.

As a unique form of electoral political violence, the insurrection was initially decried by Democrats and Republicans alike; however, in the weeks that followed, certain Republicans resisted Congressional processes to hold Mr. Trump accountable for the January 6 events (Fandos, 2021; Krakowski & Morales, 2025). For some Republicans, the events of January 6 represented a shift in the GOP toward a party that disregarded democratic processes, and therefore, was no longer representative of their beliefs. For others, despite Mr. Trump's position as the leader of this extreme shift, maintaining their party affiliation reigned supreme. Therefore, the aftermath of the January 6 events was characterized by "subsequent struggles within the Republican Party over how to respond to the insurrection", with such tension indicating the potential beginnings of intraparty realignment (Eady et al., 2023, p. 1152). In the tumultuous days that followed, news coverage across outlets greatly varied, with certain organizations emphasizing the outrageousness of the crisis - focusing on Trump as its ringleader - while others downplayed and justified the events.

This study addresses the puzzle of intraparty divergence in the aftermath of January 6: why did some Republicans reaffirm their support for Trump, while others distanced themselves? I propose that informational environments - particularly, differences in media consumption - shaped these post-insurrection reactions by influencing whether individuals perceived Trump to be responsible for the violence. While many factors indeed contributed to Republican decisions to align or de-align themselves with Trump, analyzing news consumption preferences provides insight into the mechanisms related to party affiliation in the aftermath of a violent political event. Republicans that intend to support Trump as a political figure are understood to continue aligning themselves with the Republican party, shifting toward its new extreme. Republicans who choose not to support Mr. Trump as a continuing political figure are understood to be shifting away from the GOP, indicating a potential realignment within the party itself.

Using data from the Pew Research Center's American Trends Panel, this study uses a two-stage mediation analysis to determine the odds of supporting Trump based on different Republican media diets right after January 6. Results indicate that Republicans who consumed only fringe right-wing news were significantly less likely to attribute responsibility to Trump

for the insurrection. Republicans who relied only on mainstream conservative media or neither type of outlet were more likely to perceive Trump as responsible. Accordingly, those who perceived Trump as more responsible for this act of political violence were less likely to intend to support him. The results indicate that a divide is beginning to form within the GOP, as Republicans are segmented by different media environments, and, therefore, perceptions of the event.

This draft is structured as follows. First, a review of relevant literature is presented, followed by the hypotheses explored in the study. Next, the data and methodology utilized are discussed. Subsequently, results are presented and discussed, followed by a conclusion and brief discussion of this study's implications.

2. LITERATURE

Americans are more polarized than ever (Groenendyk, 2018; Iyengar et al., 2019). Studies within the past decade have established time and time again that "ordinary Americans", in addition to political elites, increasingly dislike and distrust those from the other party"; now, more than ever, partisanship is a uniquely salient feature of Americans' social identities (Iyengar et al., 2019, p. 129; Abramowitz & Webster, 2016; Iyengar & Krupenkin, 2018). Ideological divides between Democrats and Republicans have only grown since the beginning of the 21st century, with a rise of "negative partisanship" being observed in the electorate (Abramowitz & Webster, 2016, p. 12). Existing studies, using American National Election Studies (ANES) data, reinforce this phenomenon, with recent elections being characterized by higher-than-ever levels of party loyalty and straight-ticket voting (Abramowitz & Webster, 2016, p. 12-13, Groenendyk, 2018).

While it is well-documented that partisan behavior is on the rise, interestingly, since 2016, an increasing share of U.S. voters have claimed to identify as Independents instead, with party loyalty being informed more by negativity toward the opposing party rather than positive feelings about one's own party (Abramowitz & Webster, 2016, p. 12-16). Subsequent studies have reaffirmed this notion, suggesting that partisans operate through a "lesser of two evils" approach to rationalize continuing their current party affiliation (Groenendyk, 2018, p. 159). Therefore, members of both the Republican and Democratic parties are "reporting less positive evaluations of, and greater ambivalence toward, their own party" (Groenendyk, 2018, p. 159-163). This counters previous implications of mass parties being cohesive and homogeneous entities. Given this trend of rising ambivalence towards one's own in-group, could it be possible that party identity is becoming more malleable? If it is well established that polarization and partisanship have been on the rise between the Democratic and Republican parties, then how has intraparty affect continued to evolve since the rise of the populist right in the United States in 2016?

The literature has focused on reinforcing the fact that inter-party polarization is currently extremely strong in the United States, leading to a rise in partisanship. However,

intraparty dynamics are comparatively less explored, particularly in the context of political violence events.

Political violence as a tool of suppression, control, and manifestation of political dissent is understudied in the context of a “mature democracy, where established electoral processes [and] effective accountability mechanisms”, in theory, are meant to quell episodes of political violence and its appeal (Krakowski & Morales, 2025, p. 1479; Ruggeri et al., 2025). Citizens and elites alike typically denounce political violence as an abstract concept, arguing that it erodes democratic stability by paving the way for violence to be an acceptable political tool (Zyla, 2024, p. 1481). Despite this, the insurrection at the Capitol on January 6, 2021 has been described as possibly “the most dramatic contemporary manifestation of deep political polarization in the United States” in its history, representing a “significant case of political violence with electoral motivations” (Eady et al., 2023, p. 1151; Krakowski & Morales, 2025, p. 1482). The peculiarity of the Capitol insurrection in the United States, therefore, brings up questions of polarization and how it manifested to such a degree that such a violent event could occur.

Further, when political violence is committed by a member of an opposing ideological group, it follows that the tendency is for one to feel less warmly toward the opposing party, as they have engaged in non-democratic behavior (Zyla, 2024). Similarly, when the target of an act of political violence is a member of the ideological in-group, individuals tend to prefer harsher penalties for the perpetrator, as “violence against a copartisan...might cue psychological systems that operate as though the violence exists in one’s immediate environment” (Zyla, 2024, p. 459). However, when the perpetrator is of the ideological in-group, the dynamics of party identity start to become hazy. For example, using X (formerly Twitter) data, one relevant study regarding the January 6 insurrection found that Republican politicians who were strongly associated with Trump, who is “commonly credited with the incitement of the Capitol riot”, experienced a significant drop in online support in the short-term aftermath of the insurrection (Krakowski & Morales, 2025, p. 1488). Emerging within the literature on political violence is its effects on political behavior and party identity, as exemplified by a 2023 study showing that, following January 6, a large-scale party de-identification occurred among Republican social media users - an effect that persisted in the long term (Eady et al., 2023). However, as public de-identification does not necessarily imply a true change in political behavior or beliefs, more work is necessary to determine whether partisan identities within the Republican party did indeed shift during this time.

Additionally, the literature is conflicted on whether or not partisans support perpetrators of political violence when they are members of the ideological in-group. Some scholars have demonstrated that democratic norms may remain sturdy even when citizens find themselves faced with violence (Ruggeri et al., 2025); others show that individuals support co-partisan perpetrators of political violence when such acts are justified through threat and injustice narratives (see Carreras et al., 2025; Klaus & Turnbull, 2025; Meye, 2025; Viganò et al., 2025). Therefore, it is not always a given that partisans will denounce insider perpetrators of violence in favor of stable democratic norms. The present study, therefore, investigates whether the seeds of intraparty realignment were sown in the aftermath of a violent political

act committed by an ideological in-group member, using media environments to understand how Republicans interpreted elite responsibility.

Politicians frequently use political violence to persuade supporters through processes of narrative construction, mobilizing copartisans to accept the erosion of democratic stability (Klaus & Turnbull, 2025). Nevertheless, when using violence to further political aims, actors make use of a host of strategies to justify such actions while also avoiding accountability. Most importantly, they frame the facts of the violent event in “strategic ambiguity”, thus “denying links between violent actors and politicians” (Ruggeri et al., 2025, p. 1368; Schedler, 2022). Creating blurriness around the situation allows actors to mold the narrative to their advantage. As the news form one important channel through which citizens receive and interpret such narratives, looking into news consumption habits is one avenue into exploring how support for political leaders implicated in events of political violence evolves in the aftermath of such broadly visible and shocking acts.

Of recent, with the rise of new forms of media and cable news outlets acting as competitors to network news, “partisan media outlets have reemerged in the U.S.”, moving away from journalistic standards of neutrality that had emerged in the 20th century (Levendusky, 2013, p. 565; Prior, 2007; Peterson et al., 2021). While mainstream media do make attempts to favor objectivity, while fringe outlets do no such thing (Jamieson et al., 2007; Jamieson and Cappella, 2008; Levendusky, 2013). In these outlets’ news coverage, curated facts that demonstrate issues as a mere matter of inter-party tensions “[cue] voters that they should understand these issues through the lens of partisanship” rather than neutrality, thus reinforcing in- and out-group biases (Levendusky, 2013, p. 567; Price, 1989; Yzerbyt et al., 2006). This has led to an increasingly polarized media landscape, in which outlets may selectively determine which topics are newsworthy, which issues should be emphasized, and the ideological bias, if any, used while discussing said issues. Through these choices, media outlets privilege certain frames over others, taking advantage of viewers’ predisposed attitudes, helping them “make sense of the world” while moving past the simple task of purely conveying information (Levendusky, 2013, p. 566; Rosensteel, 2006). Different framing routes allow news outlets the possibility to “[obscure] the connections between political problems and the actions or inactions of political leaders...” therefore “[weakening] the accountability of elected officials” (Iyengar, 1996, p. 59). By nature, mass media make use of frames to set references for readers to use while interpreting public events and issues (Pan & Kosicki, 1993; Scheufele, 1999).

The news media makes the construction of a specific “political reality” possible for the public (Pan & Kosicki, 1993, p. 176; Walgrave et al., 2008). A common position, as argued by Gamson and Modigliani (1989), is that changes in media discourse do not necessarily directly influence changes in public opinion, but rather that they are merely a “part of the process by which individuals construct meaning” (p. 2). Manipulation of media framing, therefore, allows consumers to select information exposure that aligns more closely with their preexisting beliefs, thus creating a reinforcement loop (Levendusky, 2013; Peterson et al., 2021).

In the context of the populist right reaching new heights of electoral power, as exemplified by the election of Donald Trump in 2016 and his continued presence as an extreme political figure within the GOP, the increasingly polarized media ecosystem is particularly relevant. Populists, from both the supply and demand sides, have unique relationships to media systems. Populist leaders often denounce traditional media sources, proclaiming them to be instruments of the 'establishment' (Mudde, 2007, p. 67). In particular, populist politicians on the right frequently attack mainstream journalists as "leftists, liars, and traitors" (Mudde, 2007, p. 67). Fringe outlets that are unrestricted by traditional reporting standards are, therefore, particularly useful for spreading populist ideas, making them more appealing to those who already support populist candidates.

Regarding the current study, partisan news reporting is particularly relevant in the context of the 2020 presidential election, as "partisanship is more pronounced when considering campaign coverage"—consumers are expected to be even more selective with their news consumption during times of high political stress, such as elections (Peterson et al., 2021, p. 2). With the development of such a polarized media ecosystem, studies have aimed to test whether watching and engaging with partisan media sources does indeed increase negative affect toward opposing parties (Levendusky, 2013; Peterson et al., 2021). For example, a series of experiments by Levendusky (2013) during the 2016 U.S. presidential campaign period, a time of heightening polarization in the United States, demonstrated that viewers of partisan media outlets do indeed "perceive the other party more negatively...trust them less, [and are] less supportive of bipartisanship", thus reinforcing blame patterns that scapegoat the opposing party rather than one's own (Levendusky, 2013, p. 565).

The literature has, therefore, extensively examined the effects of ideologically-like media consumption on citizens' political beliefs and attitudes, but it has not yet examined if these associations remain similar in the context of a major act of political violence facilitated by an in-group member. Therefore, this study aims to take this exploration further by examining intraparty dynamics within the Republican Party, particularly in the aftermath of electoral violence that generated significant controversy and was potentially disruptive to the party's dynamics. With this context in mind, the following research questions are of interest:

RQ 1 *How do patterns of media consumption shape individuals' intentions to support co-partisan elites associated with political violence after such an event, thereby beginning intraparty realignment?*

RQ 2 *How do citizen perceptions of elite responsibility for politically violent events mediate the relationship between media consumption and support for these elites?*

This article uses the January 6 attack on the U.S. Capitol as a case study through an analysis of Republican media diets, attributions of responsibility for the events to Trump, and support intentions. The following hypotheses are tested:

H1 In the aftermath of the January 6 insurrection, the effect of media consumption on support for Trump is mediated by attributions of responsibility to him for the event.

H1a Consumption of more extreme conservative media decreases the likelihood of individuals attributing responsibility.

H1b Republicans attributing more responsibility to Trump are less likely to support him as a continued political figure.

H1c The direct effect of type of media consumption on Trump support is insignificant.

Testing these hypotheses will provide insights into how distinct informational environments provide a perspective into what may be the beginning of separate constituencies forming within the Republican Party - the beginnings of intraparty realignment.

3. METHODOLOGY

Data

This paper makes use of public opinion survey data¹ from the American Trends Panel (ATP) run by the Pew Research Center, a nonpartisan American think tank headquartered in Washington, D.C. The ATP is based on a random sample of individuals surveyed across the United States across multiple waves, allowing long-term trends such as media diet to be captured. Most notably, the ATP was relevant for this study because of its survey timing, which captured respondent attitudes nearly immediately after the events of January 6, 2021. The waves being used for this study were Waves 79 and 80.

Wave 79 captured respondents' media diets prior to the election. As media diets are likely formed over time, using data for this variable that was captured prior to the events of January 6 allowed for a better picture of each respondent's general conservative media diet. Questions about media consumption in this wave focused on asking respondents whether certain mainstream sources, such as Fox News, and other outlets, including talk radio and fringe media sites, had provided the respondent with news about the presidential election since polls closed on Election Day. The questionnaire for Wave 79 was conducted from November 18 to November 29, 2020, thus capturing media consumption habits nearly right after the 2020 polls closed. Each respondent was classified into a certain group of ideologically-similar media type:

- a. **Fringe Only:** Respondents who reported consuming fringe right-wing media, but did not report consuming mainstream conservative media.
- b. **Mainstream Conservative Only:** Respondents who consumed mainstream conservative media, but did not consume fringe media.

¹ Details on [variable operationalization](#) and [descriptive statistics](#) are available in the Appendix.

- c. **Both Fringe and Mainstream Conservative:** Respondents who reported consuming at least one fringe source as well as at least one mainstream conservative source.
- d. **Neither Fringe nor Mainstream Conservative:** Respondents who did not report consuming fringe right-wing media nor mainstream conservative media.

Classification of outlets as *conservative* or *fringe* is based on the Pew Research Center's 2020 report on U.S. Media Polarization (Pew Research Center, [2020](#)).

From Wave 80, demographic variables including age, gender, income, and education categories were pulled. Additionally, information on respondent ideological stance (from very liberal to very conservative) was taken from this wave. This wave also provided information on party identification (Republican, Democrat, or party lean). Exposure to information and news about the events of January 6 was controlled for, as the variable for news consumption alone does not explain what specific types of news the respondents engaged with.

A variable measuring whether respondents attributed responsibility to Trump for the insurrection was also utilized. This variable, originally a three-category ordinal response, was re-coded into a binary (assigns responsibility/does not assign responsibility).

Lastly, the dependent variable - intentions to support Trump as a continuing political figure - was included. As Trump's association with the incitement of the January 6 events marked him as a more extreme figure within the Republican party, to analyze whether the beginnings of intraparty realignment are occurring, this is a key variable. Republican respondents who intended to support Trump as a political figure in the future were more likely to resist a split in the GOP, while those who resisted abiding by Trump are assumed to indicate a stronger tendency towards realignment.

Modeling Approach

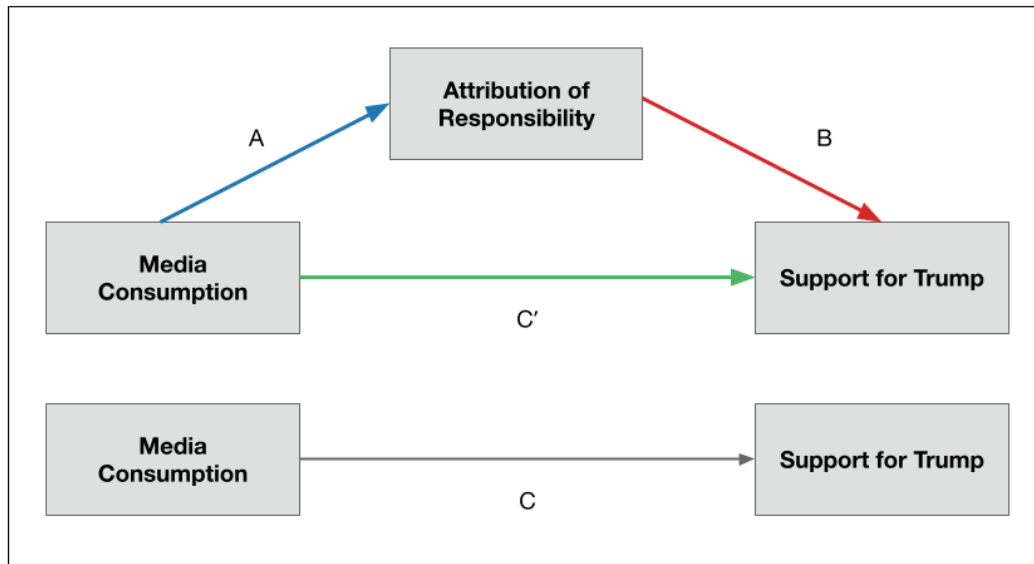
To test the hypotheses, a two-stage mediation analysis with binary logistic regression models, following the steps indicated by Baron and Kenny ([1986](#)), is utilized². All models use the appropriate survey weights to strengthen generalizability to the American population. Next, I performed bootstrapping (see Preacher & Hayes, [2004](#)) to determine statistical significance. Mediation analysis is typically performed to more thoroughly understand the mechanism behind a pre-established relationship between an independent and dependent variable; thus, the method goes beyond a simply descriptive approach of a correlation (Preacher & Hayes, [2004](#), p. 717). The treatment is assumed to indirectly affect the outcome through a mediator, which renders the direct effect of the treatment on the outcome insignificant (Baron & Kenny, [1986](#)).

[Figure 1](#) depicts this relationship between media consumption (the treatment), attributions of responsibility to Donald Trump for the January 6 insurrection (the mediator), and intentions to support Trump (the outcome).

² For model diagnostics, log odds coefficient tables, and odds ratio tables, please view the [Appendix](#). The code document is also available upon request.

Based on Baron and Kenny (1986)'s theory of mediation analysis, the first step is to test whether the independent variable must be a statistically significant predictor of the dependent variable. Therefore, Step 1 included running a weighted logistic regression that contains all the similar covariates to the final model, but without the addition of the *responsibility* mediator.

FIGURE 1: Mediation Analysis Diagram



MODEL 1: Path C

$$\text{logit}[P(\text{Support} = 1)] = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{MediaType} + \beta_2 \text{Ideology} + \beta_3 \text{Exposure} + \beta_4 \text{Gender} + \beta_5 \text{Age} + \beta_6 \text{Education} + \beta_7 \text{Income} + \varepsilon$$

The second step tests whether the treatment is a statistically significant predictor of the mediator. To do so, I ran another weighted logistic regression model regressing the mediator (responsibility attribution) on the treatment (media consumption):

MEDIATOR MODEL: Path A

$$\text{logit}[P(\text{Responsibility} = 1)] = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{MediaType} + \beta_2 \text{Ideology} + \beta_3 \text{Exposure} + \beta_4 \text{Gender} + \beta_5 \text{Age} + \beta_6 \text{Education} + \beta_7 \text{Income} + \varepsilon$$

The last two requirements that must be satisfied to conclude that a mediated relationship is present are that, when the outcome (support for Trump) is regressed on both the mediator and the treatment:

1. the mediator must be a significant predictor of the dependent variable; and,

2. the strength of the coefficient of the previously significant treatment from Step 1 is reduced - indicating partial mediation - or made insignificant, indicating full mediation (Baron & Kenny, 1986).

To test these assumptions, I estimated a third weighted logistic regression including the mediator, the treatment, and all controls:

OUTCOME MODEL: Path B

$$\text{logit}[P(\text{Support} = 1)] = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Responsibility} + \beta_2 \text{MediaType} + \beta_3 \text{Ideology} + \beta_4 \text{Gender} + \beta_5 \text{Age} + \beta_6 \text{Education} + \beta_7 \text{Income} + \varepsilon$$

To further determine statistical significance of the indirect effect through the mediator, I used bootstrapped resamples. Bootstrapping with 1,000 simulations and generating empirical confidence intervals allows us to avoid nonnormality that is likely to be present in the distribution of the indirect effect, as it is the product of coefficients (Preacher & Hayes, 2004, p. 722). This allowed the Average Causal Mediated Effect (ACME) - or indirect effect - and the Average Direct Effect (ADE) - represented by **PATH C'** - to be generated.

4. RESULTS

All steps of Baron and Kenny (1986)'s mediation method were validated. The Step 1 logistic regression was constructed to establish the relationship between media consumption and support for Trump as a continued political figure. The coefficient estimates for citizens who consume only fringe right-wing media, as well as for those who consume both fringe and mainstream conservative media, are positive, strong, and statistically significant. The coefficient for citizens who consume neither fringe nor conservative media is negative, strong, and significant. Therefore, Step 1 of Baron and Kenny (1986)'s method is satisfied; in a model without the mediator, the treatment is indeed a statistically significant predictor of the outcome.

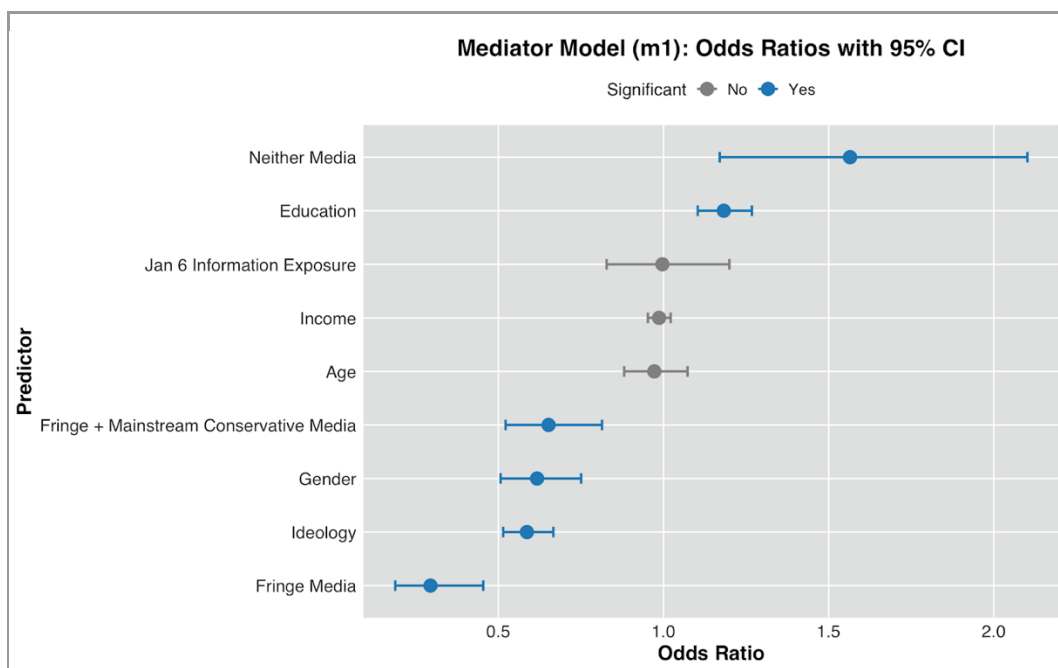
This allows us to continue estimating the models of interest that will elaborate the mechanism behind the relationship between media consumption and support for Trump. Firstly, the mediator model (Figure 2 and Figure 3) tested the relationship between media consumption and attribution of responsibility to Donald Trump for the events of January 6.

For respondents who only consume fringe right-wing media, the odds of attributing responsibility to Trump for January 6 for citizens who only consume fringe right-wing media, compared to the reference of people who only consume mainstream conservative media, decrease by approximately 70.55% ($p < 0.001$). For citizens who consume both fringe and mainstream conservative media, the odds of attributing responsibility for those within this consumption group are approximately 34.8% ($p < 0.001$) less than those who only consume

mainstream conservative media. For those who consume neither fringe nor mainstream conservative media, the odds of attributing responsibility to Trump, compared to the reference group, were about 56.47% ($p < 0.01$) greater. These results confirm **H1a**.

Other significant predictors in this model were *ideology* ($p < 0.001$), *gender* ($p < 0.001$), and *education* ($p < 0.001$). A one-unit step toward the conservative end of the ideological spectrum was associated with a 41.35% decrease in the odds of attributing responsibility. Being male decreased the odds of attributing responsibility by approximately 38.29%. Lastly, those who were more highly educated showed an increase in the odds of attributing responsibility by about 18.24%. Exposure to information about January 6, age, and income were all nonsignificant predictors in the mediator model.

FIGURE 2: Odds Ratios for Mediator Model (Path A)



The next step, the outcome model (Figure 4 and Figure 5), tested the relationship between responsibility attribution and support for Trump as a continuing political figure, including both the treatment (media consumption) and the mediator (responsibility attribution).

Attributing responsibility to Trump reduced the odds of support by about 89.29% ($p < 0.001$) compared to those who did not consider Trump responsible for the events of January 6. This result confirms **H1b**.

The odds of supporting Trump were found to be 85.51% ($p < 0.001$) greater for those who consume both fringe and mainstream conservative media compared to the reference group. As the coefficient for this media group (0.618) was both smaller than the Step 1 coefficient (0.695) as well as significant, this indicates that the relationship between the *Both*

media group and support for Trump is only partially mediated by attributions of responsibility (Baron & Kenny, 1986).

FIGURE 3: Predicted Probabilities - Responsibility for January 6 (Path A)

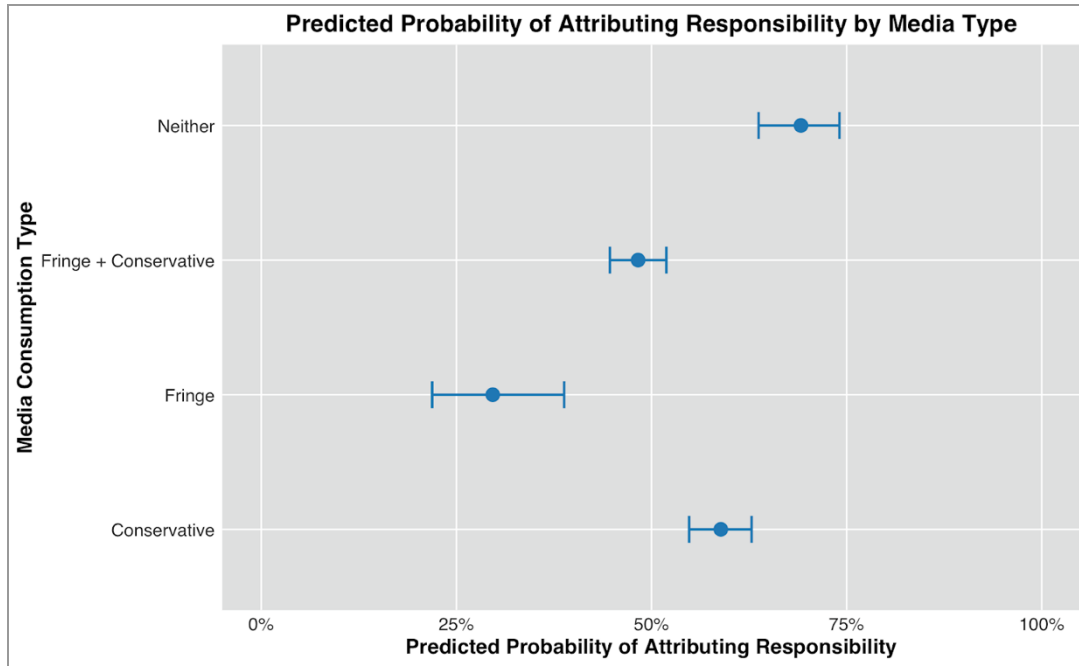
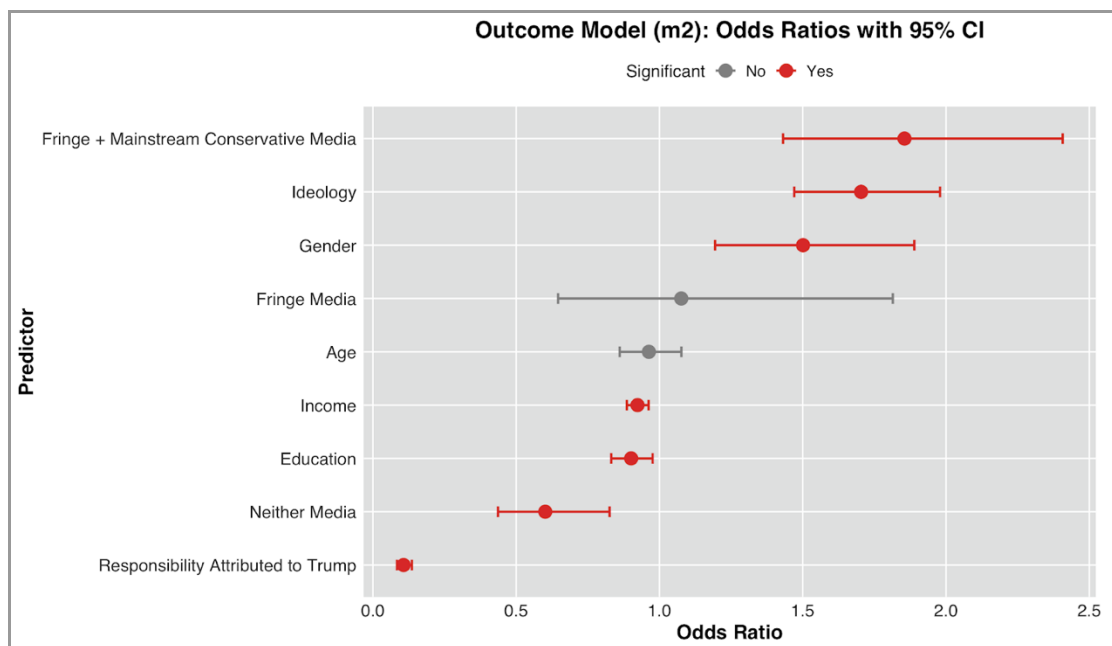


FIGURE 4: Odds Ratios for Outcome Model (Path B)

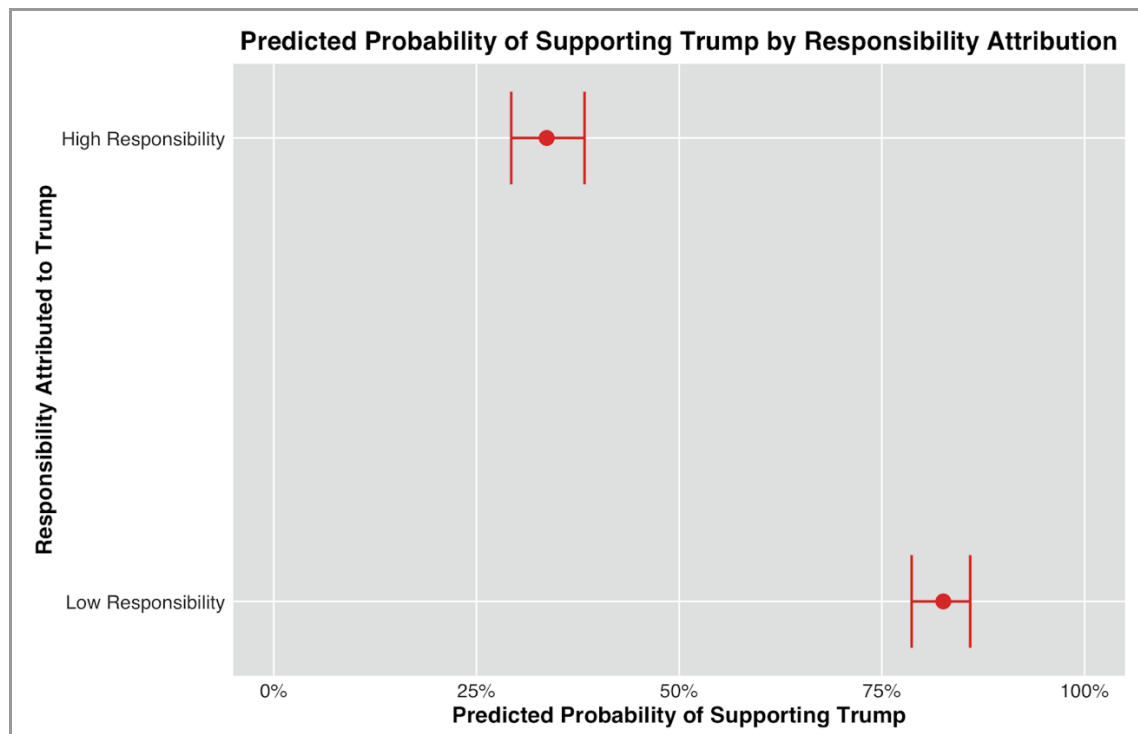


Consumers of neither fringe nor conservative media were found to have a 39.85% ($p < 0.01$) decrease in the odds of supporting Trump compared to the reference group. This coefficient (-0.508) is smaller in magnitude than the Step 1 effect (-0.634) and significant; therefore, partial mediation is once again implicated here (Baron & Kenny, 1986).

Fringe right-wing media consumption was no longer a significant indicator of support for Trump; the magnitude of the coefficient of fringe media consumption for the outcome model (0.073) was smaller than the first effect estimated in Step 1 (0.598). This indicates that the relationship between exclusively fringe media consumption and support for Trump is fully mediated by attributions of responsibility to him (Baron & Kenny, 1986).

Other significant predictors include *ideology*, *gender*, *education*, and *income*. Those who are more conservative are found to have a 70.38% ($p < 0.001$) increase in the odds of supporting Trump. Respondents who are male experience a 50.11% ($p < 0.001$) increase in the odds of supporting Trump. Those with higher education show a 9.89% ($p < 0.05$) decrease in the odds of supporting Trump, while those with higher incomes similarly show a small decrease in the odds of support, by 7.66% ($p < 0.001$).

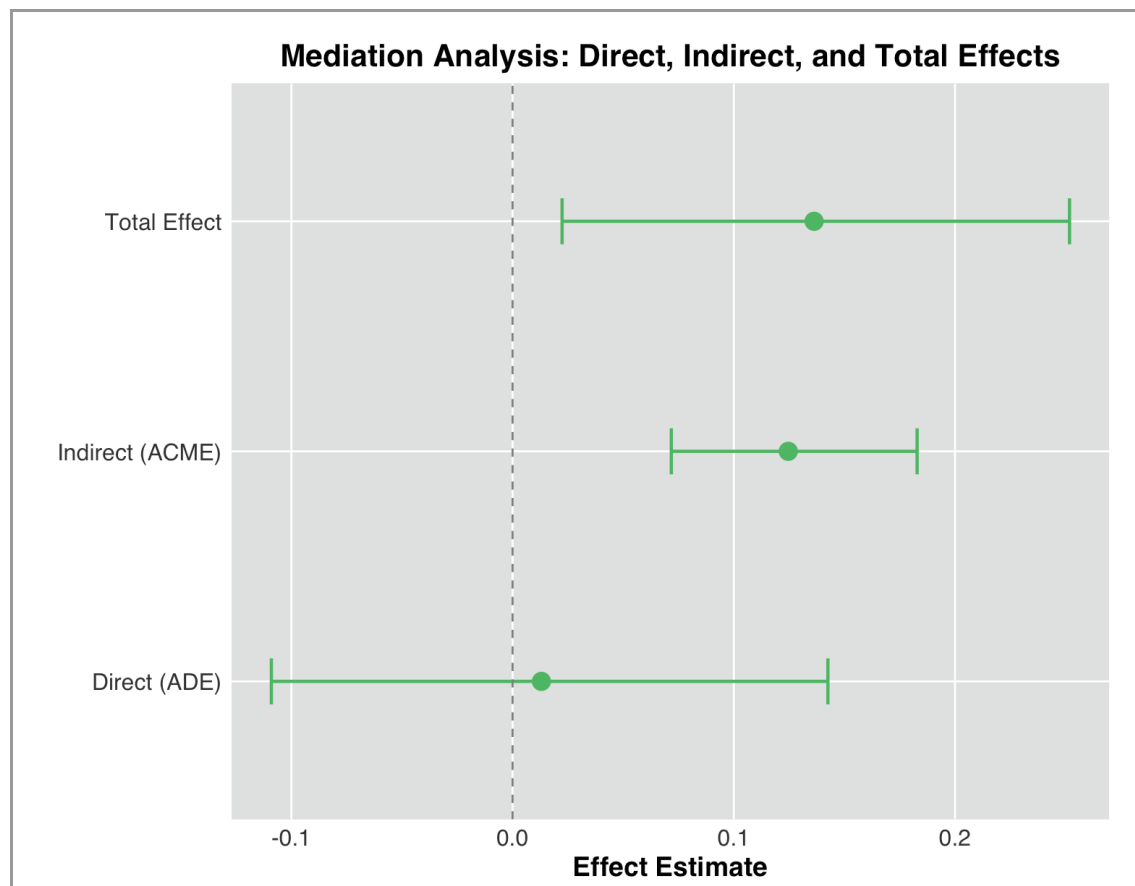
FIGURE 5: Predicted Probabilities of Supporting Trump (Path B)



Finally, running the mediation analysis (Figure 6) using 1,000 bootstrapped simulations allowed for an estimate of the statistical significance of the Average Causal Mediated Effect (ACME) and the Average Direct Effect (ADE) of the relationship between media consumption and support for Trump in the aftermath of January 6. The ADE was 0.012 and insignificant, indicating that type of media consumption has little to no direct effect on Trump support.

This result confirms **H1c**. The ACME, or indirect effect, was about 0.124 and significant at the $p < 0.001$ level, indicating that media type does indeed indirectly affect Trump support through the mechanism of responsibility attribution. The total effect was 0.136 and significant at the $p < 0.05$ level, indicating that media type does affect support. Nearly all of this total effect of media on Trump support is mediated by attributions of responsibility; the average proportion mediated is 91%. This validates **H1** - the effect of media consumption on support for Trump is mediated by attributions of responsibility to him for the event.

FIGURE 6: Mediation Analysis (Path C')



5. DISCUSSION

This study set out to examine whether Republicans' interpretations of the January 6 attack on the U.S. capitol, and resulting levels of support for Donald Trump, reflect the beginnings of deeper breaks within the party, signalling early-stage intraparty realignment. The above results provide evidence that, within the Republican party, media-driven information environments do indeed segment the electorate through differing interpretations of political violence and, in turn, varying assessments of Trump as a central party leader.

The findings show that, even among members of the same party, different informational worlds are at play. These informational divides are particularly important among Republicans in the Trump era, when partisan identity has become more blurry (Groenendyk, 2018) and the populist right is beginning to reorient the party. The polarized media ecosystem described in prior work (Levendusky, 2013; Peterson et al., 2021) appears to play a role in the GOP's realignment. The present analysis showed that Republicans consuming only fringe right-wing news, which are known to do away with traditional journalistic norms of objectivity, were significantly less likely to attribute responsibility to Trump for the Capitol insurrection (Jamieson et al., 2007; Jamieson & Cappella, 2008; Levendusky, 2013; Peterson et al., 2021; Prior, 2007). In contrast, Republicans relying only on mainstream conservative outlets, or neither mainstream nor fringe channels, were more likely to perceive Trump as responsible for the January 6 events. This pattern reflects the power of media framing in informing perceptions of political reality, particularly during periods of heightened tension (Walgrave et al., 2008; Pan & Kosicki, 1993).

Responsibility attribution served as a significant mediator of the relationship between media consumption and support for Trump as a continuing political figure. The fact that a large percentage of the media type effect on support was indirect suggests that media ecosystems, while reinforcing preexisting attitudes, also actively structure the interpretive frameworks through which individuals make sense of political violence, while reinforcing Gamson and Modigliani (1989)'s theory of indirect media effects. Republicans who were more exposed to fringe news were not merely more pro-Trump; they were led to a fundamentally different understanding of what happened on January 6, who should be held accountable, and justifications for the events. These results complicate the idea that partisans reflexively support co-partisans involved in political violence. Their support is not unconditional: it emerges when they are persuaded (through the news, for instance) that the in-group member was either not truly responsible or, if they were, that their actions were justified. This finding, therefore, relates to prior research that shows political violence by an in-group member disrupting traditional patterns of party loyalty (Krakowski & Morales, 2025; Zyla, 2024), while adding new evidence that media frames may indeed play a role in determining how this disruption occurs.

The literature has shown that rising ambivalence within party identities as well as growing heterogeneity in partisans' relationships to their own party elites is occurring (Groenendyk, 2018). This study shows that Republicans, despite all having proximity to the same party, do not uniformly process the same events of political science - nor do they converge upon one shared understanding of the party's leadership as exemplified by Donald Trump. Instead, distinct media environments appear to be developing separate interpretive and evaluative constituencies within the GOP; one is centered around narratives that either deflect or justify political violence perpetrated by an elite insider, while the other is grounded in more mainstream informational sources. Those who engage more with fringe news exhibit a strong loyalty to Trump even in the wake of political violence, while those who do not are more likely to assign responsibility and reevaluate their support for a central party leader. Therefore, the

beginnings of intraparty realignment in the GOP may be partially driven by fundamentally different perceptions of political reality.

It is necessary to acknowledge the limitations of this study. Firstly, given that the data is derived from survey responses, social desirability bias may play a role. Particularly in the recent aftermath of January 6, of which the events were decried by numerous groups and entities, respondents may be reluctant to divulge their true political beliefs and sources of news out of shame.

Additionally, when listing different types of news content, the survey question measuring media outlet reliance only provided limited examples of each type of source. Therefore, respondents may have believed they could only indicate that they used that type of media if they used the exact outlets listed as examples in the question, leading to inaccurate media use reporting. The subsequent classification of these media types into “fringe” and “mainstream” may also lose nuance; not all mainstream media organizations nor fringe outlets report the same way.

Thirdly, although a mediation analysis implies causal pathways, we must still be cautious in making causal claims. Bidirectionality of the relationship between media consumption and responsibility - as well as between media consumption and Trump support - is indeed possible. As this study makes use of cross-sectional data, the causal ordering assumed in the mediation model is not empirically verified.

Lastly, it is essential to note that the results of this study only reflect short-term, immediate attitudes, rather than long-term effects. It is possible that Republicans who, in the initial weeks after January 6, 2021, felt a disconnect from the Republican party, later re-identified or re-solidified their alignment with the in-group so as to not lose benefits from membership (Krakowski & Morales, [2025](#)).

6. CONCLUSION

This article set out to address the questions: How do patterns of media consumption shape individuals' intentions to support co-partisan elites associated with political violence after such an event? How do citizen perceptions of elite responsibility for politically violent events mediate that relationship? The results showed that the type of news Republicans consumed strongly predicted whether individuals attributed responsibility to Trump for the January 6 insurrection; additionally, responsibility attribution proved to be a meaningful predictor of support for Trump as a continuing political figure. The mediation analysis showed that nearly all of the effect of media consumption on support operates through this mechanism: the more fringe the media environment, the less likely respondents were to perceive Trump as responsible, and the more likely they were to support him. Therefore, following January 6, Republicans did not react as a uniform bloc to this in-group transgression. Rather, they interpreted the same event through much different lenses. In this way, the events of January 6, 2021 did not simply intensify interparty polarization, as would be expected; they also

revealed potential fault lines within the GOP. Therefore, these findings contribute to a broader understanding of how partisan media ecosystems shape elite accountability in moments of political crisis, revealing that media-driven interpretations of political violence can meaningfully alter the trajectory of elite support within a party. An avenue that can take this analysis further in the future would be to analyze the very frames used by the news media in the context of political violence, thus adding more clarity to the mechanisms through which informational environments shape perceptions of elite responsibility and democratic accountability. Future research on this topic should also address the democratic consequences of these dynamics, including their potential to contribute to backsliding in the United States. While the present study does not directly address democratic backsliding, the findings implicate a key mechanism associated with it: media environments can protect political elites from accountability for violating democratic norms. This allows politicians associated with political violence to influence segments of the population to view democratic institutions as illegitimate and violence against them as justified (Druckman, [2024](#)).

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8. APPENDIX

TABLE A1: Descriptive Statistics. N = 1883

Variables	Mean	SD	Median	Min	Max	Range	SE
Responsibility	0.548	0.498	1	0	1	1	0.011
Media Type	2.409	1.122	3	1	4	3	0.026
Ideology	3.762	0.772	4	1	5	4	0.018
Gender	0.505	0.500	1	0	1	1	0.012
Age	2.791	0.948	3	1	4	3	0.022
Education	3.714	1.576	4	1	6	5	0.036
Income	5.161	3.030	5	1	9	8	0.070
Exposure	2.651	0.519	3	1	3	2	0.012
Party ID	1	0	1	1	1	0	0

TABLE A2: Variable Operationalization

Note: Table A2 continues across multiple pages.

Variable	Description
<i>Dependent variable (Outcome Model)</i>	
Intentions to support Trump as a continuing major political figure.	Coded into a binary variable: 0 = no intention to support 1 = intention to support
<i>Dependent variable (Mediator Model)</i>	
Perception of Trump as responsible for the violence and destruction committed at the Capitol on January 6, 2021.	Coded into a binary variable: 0 = does not consider Trump responsible 1 = considers Trump responsible
<i>Independent Variable and Controls</i>	

Media Type	Respondents were sorted into the 4 following groups depending on if they mentioned watching Fox News (mainstream conservative media), right-wing talk radio (fringe media), both, or neither. (a) Fringe only (b) Mainstream conservative only (c) Both fringe and mainstream conservative (d) Neither fringe nor mainstream conservative
Age	Age from the following categories: 1 = 18-29 years 2 = 30-49 years 3 = 50-64 years 4 = 65 years and more
Gender	Coded into a binary variable: 0 = male 1 = female
Education	Education level: 1 = Less than high school 2 = High school graduate 3 = Some college, no degree 4 = Associate's degree 5 = College graduate/some post-grad 6 = Postgraduate

Income	Gross yearly income from the following categories: 1 = Less than \$30,000 2 = \$30,000 to less than \$40,000 3 = \$40,000 to less than \$50,000 4 = \$50,000 to less than \$60,000 5 = \$60,000 to less than \$70,000 6 = \$70,000 to less than \$80,000 7 = \$80,000 to less than \$90,000 8 = \$90,000 to less than \$100,000 9 = \$100,000 or more
Ideological Position	Likert scale from 1-5 1 = Most liberal 10 = Most conservative
Party Identification	Binary; dataset filtered to only include Republicans/Republican leaners. 1 = Republican/Lean Republican 2 = Democrat/Lean Democrat
Exposure to news and information about January 6.	Likert scale from 1-3 (Releveled for interpretability) 1 = Heard nothing at all 2 = Heard a little 3 = Heard a lot

End of Table A2.

TABLE A3: Log-Odds Coefficients for Step 1 Model

	(1)
Intercept	-1.301*** (<0.001)
Fringe Media	0.598** (0.008)
Fringe + Conservative Media	0.695*** (<0.001)
Neither Media	-0.634*** (<0.001)
Ideology	0.672*** (<0.001)
Exposure to Jan 6 Information	-0.144 (0.139)
Gender	0.521*** (<0.001)
Age	-0.010 (0.841)
Education	-0.164*** (<0.001)
Income	-0.060** (0.001)
Num.Obs.	1898
AIC	2332.6
BIC	2388.1
Log.Lik.	-1156.309
RMSE	0.45
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001	

TABLE A4: Log-Odds Coefficients for Mediator Model and Outcome Model

	Mediator Model (m1)	Outcome Model (m2)
Fringe Media	-1.223*** (<0.001)	0.073 (0.780)
Fringe + Conservative Media	-0.428*** (<0.001)	0.618*** (<0.001)
Neither Media	0.448** (0.003)	-0.508** (0.002)
Responsibility Attributed		-2.234*** (<0.001)
Ideology	-0.534*** (<0.001)	0.533*** (<0.001)
Jan 6 Information Exposure	-0.003 (0.971)	
Gender	-0.483*** (<0.001)	0.406*** (<0.001)
Age	-0.028 (0.572)	-0.038 (0.509)
Education	0.168*** (<0.001)	-0.104* (0.011)
Income	-0.013 (0.450)	-0.080*** (<0.001)
Intercept	2.144*** (<0.001)	0.241 (0.464)
Num.Obs.	1883	1883
AIC	2456.7	1909.7
BIC	2512.1	1965.1
Log.Lik.	-1218.368	-944.863
F	20.569	52.194
RMSE	0.46	0.40
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001		

TABLE A5: Odds Ratios for Mediator Model and Outcome Model

	Mediator Model (m1)	Outcome Model (m2)
Fringe Media	0.294*** (<0.001)	1.076 (0.780)
Fringe + Conservative Media	0.652*** (<0.001)	1.855*** (<0.001)
Neither Media	1.565** (0.003)	0.601** (0.002)
Responsibility Attributed		0.107*** (<0.001)
Ideology	0.586*** (<0.001)	1.704*** (<0.001)
Jan 6 Information Exposure	0.997 (0.971)	
Gender	0.617*** (<0.001)	1.501*** (<0.001)
Age	0.972 (0.572)	0.963 (0.509)
Education	1.182*** (<0.001)	0.901* (0.011)
Income	0.987 (0.450)	0.923*** (<0.001)
Intercept	8.533*** (<0.001)	1.272 (0.464)
Num.Obs.	1883	1883
AIC	2456.7	1909.7
BIC	2512.1	1965.1
Log.Lik.	-1218.368	-944.863
F	20.569	52.194
RMSE	0.46	0.40
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001		

TABLE A6: Bootstrapped Mediation Analysis Results

Causal Mediation Analysis

Nonparametric Bootstrap Confidence Intervals with the Percentile Method

	Estimate	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	p-value	
ACME (control)	0.136935	0.075814	0.184075	<2e-16	***
ACME (treated)	0.135385	0.068295	0.186190	<2e-16	***
ADE (control)	0.013040	-0.109091	0.153274	0.904	
ADE (treated)	0.011490	-0.103882	0.129763	0.904	
Total Effect	0.148425	0.025962	0.251906	0.020	*
Prop. Mediated (control)	0.922586	0.383465	3.242752	0.020	*
Prop. Mediated (treated)	0.912146	0.304746	3.357057	0.020	*
ACME (average)	0.136160	0.073723	0.185421	<2e-16	***
ADE (average)	0.012265	-0.106224	0.140611	0.904	
Prop. Mediated (average)	0.917366	0.345949	3.293650	0.020	*

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Sample Size Used: 1883

Simulations: 1000